Dear incoming MCC Environmental Steward at Hurricane Island Center for Science and Leadership,

Welcome to Maine Conservation Corps (MCC) and your host site at Hurricane Island!!

I know you must be stoked, and ready for a summer of educating, inspiring conservation, and personal and professional growth. I hope this letter serves to introduce you to what to expect and has some helpful advice.

Kicking it right off, I would suggest that you take advantage of the ability to get Wilderness First Responder certified. The course is often offered by Hurricane Island, on Hurricane Island, which is super convenient. It was an incredible opportunity to learn what to do if someone is hurt without close hospital access. It also served as a bonding experience with staff members and allowed me to settle into life on the island. A similar bonding opportunity happens with MCC training and events. I know that everything might seem super new and there are so many new things to keep track of but here is my advice to slow down, get to know your fellow Environmental Stewards that are starting at the same time as you, and don't hesitate to ask for help.

Speaking of the island, as I'm sure you know, you will be living on a remote island off the coast of Rockland, Maine. This means that hot water and electricity are not always at the touch of your fingers, and composting toilets are the norm. Take the packing lists and recommendations for clothing layers, a good sleeping bag, and perhaps a hot water bottle seriously! This also means that you will be living in a fascinating environment (perhaps a hummingbird will fly into your outhouse in the morning), with insane ocean views (from brilliant sunsets to sweeping fog), and a supportive and fun community.

Serving on the Education Team at Hurricane is an extremely fun, rewarding, and adventurous experience. You will be learning new lesson plans quite quickly, training in student swimming and exploration policies, and even diving into creating new curriculum and schedules over the course of your service. Lessons are very hands-on and place-based, and some example lessons you might lead are plankton labs, identifying freshwater macroinvertebrates, and dissecting scallops. You will also lead educational hikes speaking about the history and sustainable systems of the island.

Take advantage of opportunities to learn other skills such as boat operations, facilities, or working in the kitchen, if you are interested. Also, AmeriCorps training and conferences are great ways to meet new conservation- and community- focused folks, and to share and reflect on your MCC Environmental Steward experience. Everyone at Hurricane and MCC is welcoming and there to support you in your service and professional/personal development.

Wishing you the best, and have fun!!
-Ava Birdwell (MCC ES 2026)